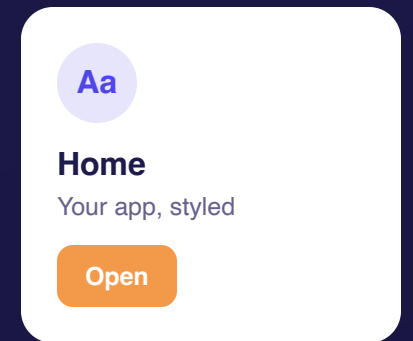


Wireframing Your App

Sketching every screen - and how they break into components - before you write a single line of JSX.

Goal for today: map your app's screens and sections, and the flow between them, on paper.



THE PLAN

How this session runs · ~45 minutes

1

Learn the how

What a wireframe is, fidelity, and the drawing conventions everyone uses.

~12 min

2

See a real screen flow

Walk through a finished responsive wireframe and its component tree, together.

~8 min

3

Sketch your own

Pen & paper - your app's screens at phone and desktop width, plus the flow between them.

~20 min

4

Pair & share

Explain your navigation and your component breakdown to a partner.

~5 min

This continues straight from your Proposal (Doc 1) - your section list should already exist.

DEFINITION

So what is a wireframe?

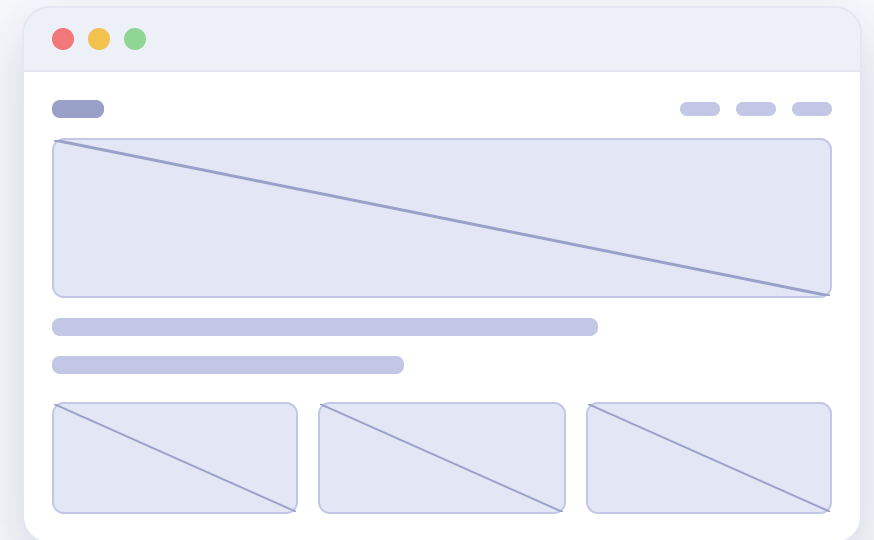
A low-fidelity, greyscale blueprint of a screen. It shows structure, layout, and where content goes - not colors, not final icons, not real text.

Think of an architect's floor plan: you decide where the rooms go before you pick the paint and furniture.

Greyscale

Boxes & lines

Placeholders only



CLEARING UP CONFUSION

Wireframe ≠ mockup ≠ prototype



Wireframe

WHERE THINGS GO

Structure & layout in greyscale. Boxes, lines, placeholders.



Mockup

HOW IT LOOKS

Adds the visual layer: real colors, type, icons, branding.



Prototype

HOW IT BEHAVES

Adds interactivity - clickable, simulates the real app.

Today we stay all the way on the left. Don't jump ahead to colors and interaction.

WHY BOTHER

Why sketch on paper first?



Fail cheap

Moving a box on paper takes seconds. Moving it after you've built the component tree takes an afternoon.



Focus on structure

No color or fonts to fuss over, so you actually think about hierarchy and flow - the stuff that matters.



Honest feedback

Because it looks unfinished, people critique the layout instead of saying "I don't like that blue."



Think fast, freely

Paper is judgement-free. Sketch three to five versions in the time one React screen would take.

A WORD YOU'LL HEAR A LOT

Fidelity: low vs high

Fidelity = how much detail and realism a wireframe has. NN/g notes it varies across three things:

Interactivity

Visuals

Content

LOW-FIDELITY (TODAY)

- Quick greyscale boxes & lines
- Hand-drawn, rough on purpose
- No real content or interaction
- Fast to make, faster to change

Start here. Cheap to throw away.

HIGH-FIDELITY (THE BUILD)

- Detailed, close to the real app
- Real spacing, type, your palette
- Built directly as React components
- Styled using your design system (Doc 3)

Comes after the structure is settled.

THE SHORTHAND

How to "draw" things in a wireframe

A handful of conventions everyone understands. Learn these and your sketch reads instantly.



Image / photo



Heading + body



Button / CTA



Top nav bar



Footer

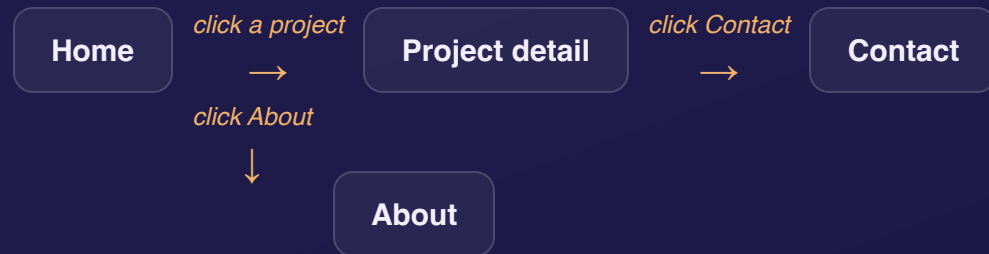


Input field

BEFORE YOU DRAW A SINGLE SCREEN

Map the flow first

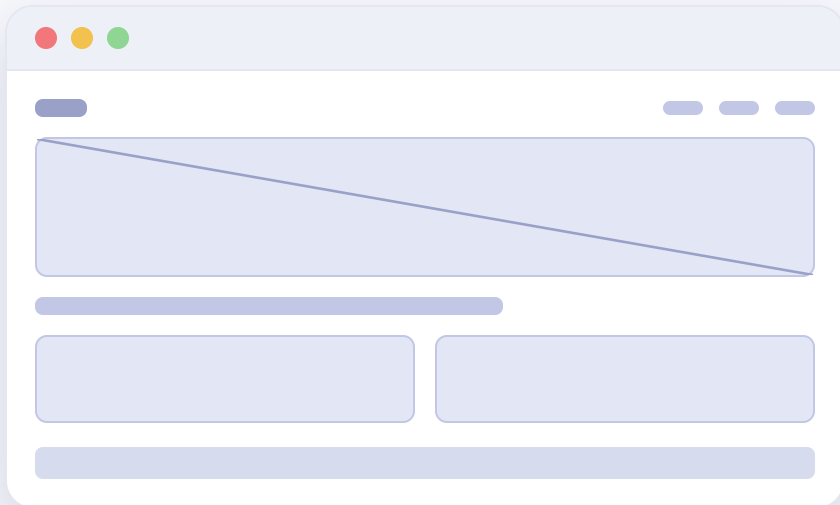
Your app is a set of screens or sections connected by clicks. Draw every one as a labeled box, and every way to move between them as an arrow, labeled with the action that triggers it.



Questions this should answer: what's the **first screen** a user sees? Is there a **home base** most screens return to (your nav)? Any screen with **no way back**?

Multi-route app? Each box becomes a React Router <Route>. Single-page? Each box is a scroll section the nav jumps to. Ref: React Router docs

Anatomy of a typical web screen



1

Header & nav

Site title and links - the `<header>` and `<nav>` landmarks.

2

Main

The page's primary content - the `<main>` landmark.

3

Sections

Distinct blocks: hero, About, Projects - each a `<section>`.

4

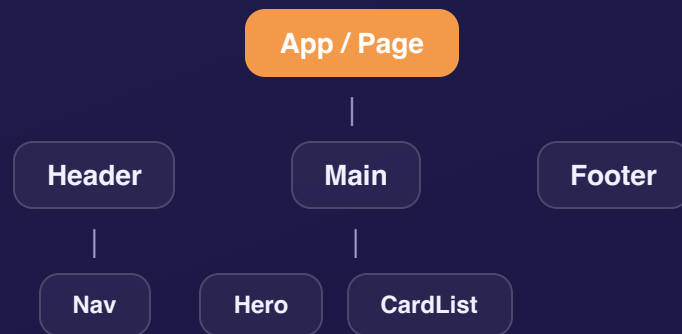
Footer

Contact, copyright, links - the `<footer>` landmark.

THE REACT-SPECIFIC STEP

Every box is a component

A wireframe hands React something extra: draw a box around every **repeated** or **self-contained** piece, and each one becomes a component you build once and reuse.



- **Atoms** - the smallest pieces: Button, Input, Tag
- **Molecules** - a few atoms joined: Card, SearchBar
- **Organisms** - whole sections: Header, ProjectsGrid
- **Page** - the screen that arranges the organisms

The rule: a repeated box is a real component. If a card shows five times, you build `<Card />` once and render it in a list with keys.

THE SINGLE MOST IMPORTANT SKILL

Build a visual hierarchy

Guide the eye to the most important thing first. You control that with three levers:



Scale

Make the most important element the biggest. Limit yourself to ~2 big things.



Contrast

Use weight, value, or one accent color to make key items pop from the rest.



Grouping

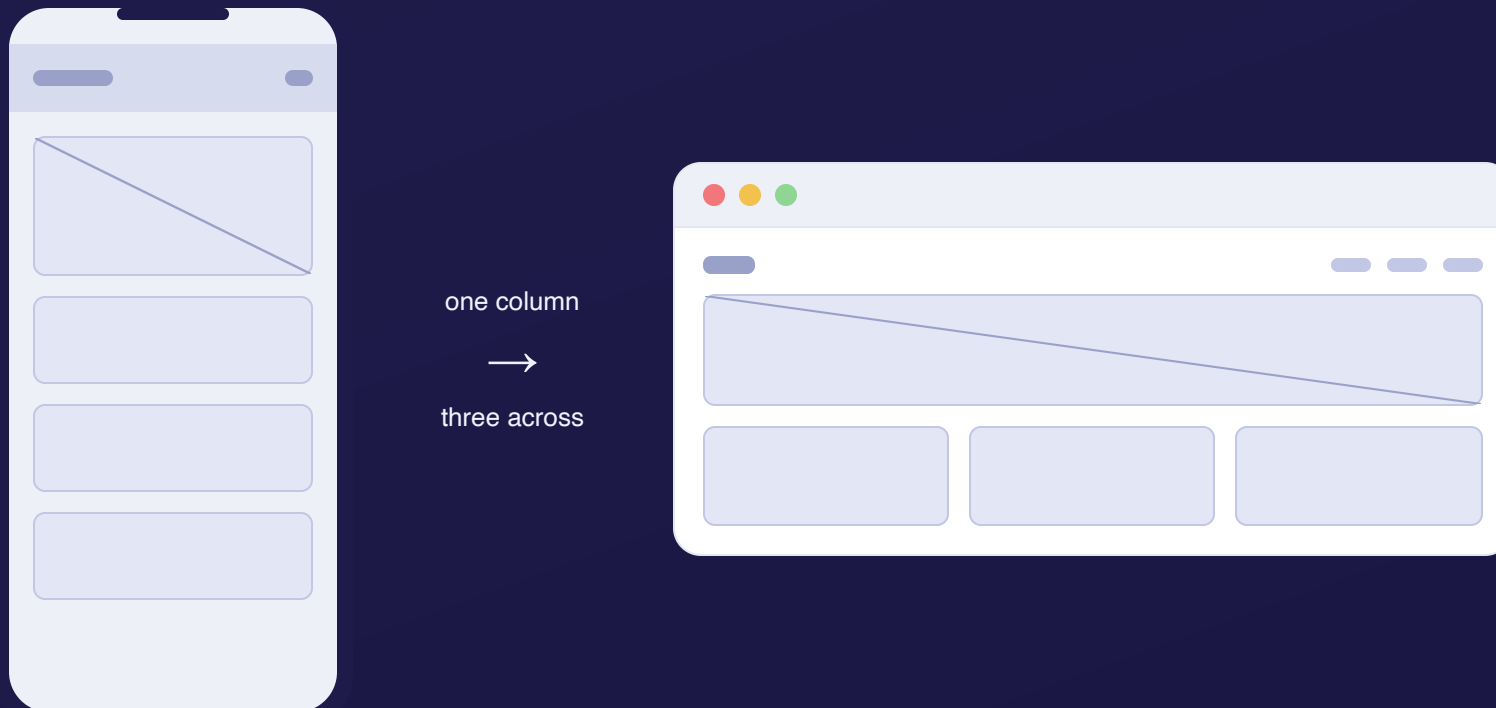
Place related things together; use whitespace to separate sections.

Rule of thumb: use only 2–3 text sizes (heading, subhead, body). The "squint test" - blur your eyes; the most important thing should still stand out.

THE WEB REFLows - PLAN BOTH WIDTHS

Sketch phone and desktop

Your app is graded at a **375px phone** (no horizontal scrolling) and a wide screen. The same content, different layout - so wireframe both now, and note what stacks.



Your "what stacks" notes become media queries (or Tailwind's `md :` prefixes) built with Flexbox and Grid. Ref: [m3-styling/05 - Responsive layout](#)

THE HOW, STEP BY STEP

Your wireframing process

1

Know the goal

Who opens this screen, and what should they walk away doing?

2

Inventory content

List what each screen actually needs - text, buttons, data. Group it.

3

Sketch 3–5 versions

Thumbnails. Don't marry your first layout - explore a few.

4

Pick & flesh out

Choose the strongest. Add detail top→bottom, at both widths.

5

Label & name components

Annotate each block: what it is, and which component it becomes.

6

Get feedback, iterate

Show someone. Revise. Cheap now, expensive after you've coded it.

KEEP IT HONEST

Do this, not that



DO

- Draft, don't draw - rough is good
- Stay greyscale: boxes & lines only
- Label every block and name its component
- Map the flow before detailing screens
- Sketch phone and desktop both

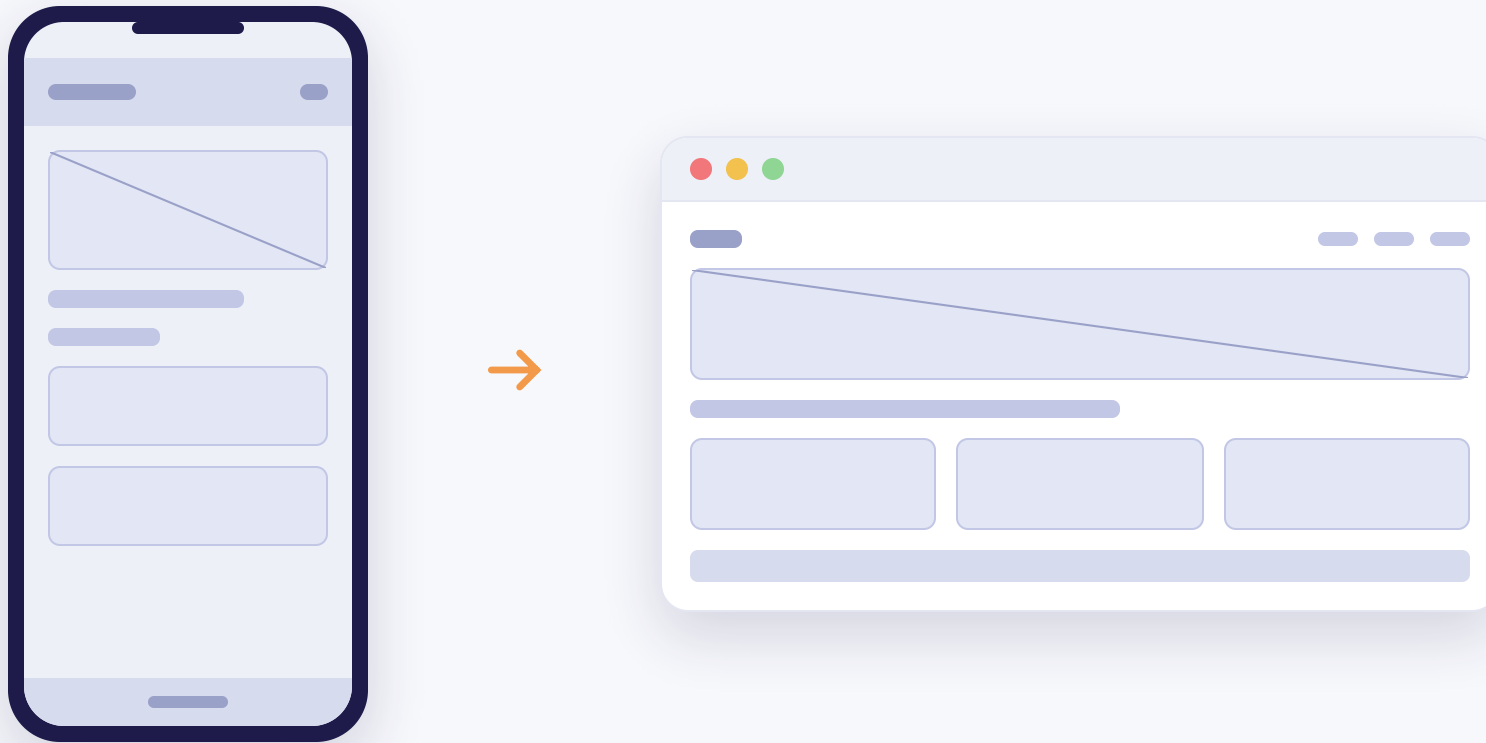


DON'T

- Don't add color or icons yet
- Don't chase perfect alignment
- Don't drop in final copy or photos
- Don't design a screen with no way back
- Don't skip the goal step

PUTTING IT TOGETHER

A finished low-fi wireframe



Read it screen by screen:

- Header + nav, same on every screen
- Hero, then a grid of cards
- Phone: one column. Desktop: three across
- Footer with contact + links
- All greyscale - structure only

Illustrative example built on the conventions from the previous slides.

Sketch your app - on paper

The brief

Wireframe YOUR app. Pen & paper, greyscale only. Draw your **two most important screens** at **phone and desktop width**, plus the flow between them.

Every screen should show:

Header + nav · primary content · one clear action · footer

Follow the process: 1) goal 2) inventory 3) thumbnail 2–3 layouts 4) pick + detail 5) label + name components 6) draw the flow arrows

Ground rules

- No color, no real icons
- Squint test before you finish
- Mark what stacks on a phone
- Label every block and name its component

Deliverable

Labeled paper wireframes for every screen on your list, connected by a flow map, with a first-pass component tree. Keep this - it becomes your React component tree.

What "good" looks like



Clear hierarchy

Squint, and the most important thing still jumps out.



Logical flow

Every arrow matches how a real user would actually navigate.



Named components

Every repeated box has a component name. Your tree is half-built already.



Refloids cleanly

Phone stacks to one column; desktop spreads out. No sideways scroll.

Next: Design System (Doc 3) - the tokens, type, and reusable components that turn these boxes into a real React theme.

Pair critique + quick gallery walk - keep feedback on structure, not style.

REFERENCES

Sources

- **Nielsen Norman Group** - "Visual Hierarchy in UX" & "5 Principles of Visual Design" (nngroup.com)
- **Nielsen Norman Group** - "UX Prototypes: Low Fidelity vs. High Fidelity" (K. Pernice, nngroup.com)
- **Brad Frost** - Atomic Design: breaking a UI into components (atomicdesign.bradfrost.com)
- **React documentation** - "Thinking in React"; React Router - routing (react.dev; reactrouter.com)
- **MDN Web Docs** - HTML landmark elements; Using Flexbox and Grid (developer.mozilla.org)
- **CareerFoundry** - "How to Create Your First Wireframe" (careerfoundry.com)
- **Balsamiq** - "How to Start a Wireframe" (balsamiq.com/blog)
- **UXPin** - "How to Create a Wireframe: Step-by-Step Guide" (uxpin.com)
- **Justinmind** - "What is a Wireframe? Step-by-Step Guide" (justinmind.com)
- **Uxcel** - "The Complete UX/UI Guide to Creating a Wireframe" (uxcel.com)
- **AND Academy** - "Step-by-Step Guide to Wireframe Design" (andacademy.com)